

AN ORIGINAL SCIENCE-FICTION FEATURE

9998

STUDIO SUBMISSION PACKAGE

Written by Lawrence Ligad Jr.

In a future where reincarnation has become state-controlled infrastructure, a man carrying the archived pattern of its inventor awakens as an anomalous 9,998th iteration and must decide whether inherited memory determines identity before an immortal ruler collapses humanity's consciousness into himself.

Elevated science fiction | 85-page feature | Updated September 2026

Project Overview

TITLE 9998

FORMAT Original science-fiction feature screenplay

GENRE Elevated science fiction / emotional thriller

LENGTH 85 pages

SETTING Chronos City, Earth, year 9998 - with authenticated records reaching back to 8122

Logline

In a future where reincarnation has become state-controlled infrastructure, a man carrying the archived pattern of its inventor awakens as an anomalous 9,998th iteration and must decide whether inherited memory determines identity before an immortal ruler collapses humanity's consciousness into himself.

The Commercial Hook

9998 turns the question "What survives death?" into a human-scale pursuit. The Chronocracy preserves memory, grows replacement bodies and assigns identities, but Kerr wakes unable to accept the life chosen for him. His search for the women appearing in his drawings becomes a race against a seventy-two-hour purge and a fight to keep every returning person from being claimed by the past.

Positioning

The project sits between cerebral event science fiction and emotionally accessible identity drama. Its pitch shorthand is *Arrival* meets *Blade Runner 2049*, with the fractured-memory intimacy of *Eternal Sunshine of the Spotless Mind* and the reincarnation scope of *Cloud Atlas*. These references indicate audience and tonal territory, not equivalence of execution, scale or commercial performance.

Why This Film

The film asks a contemporary question through speculative mythology: if an institution can reconstruct a person from data, who gets to name the result? The answer emerges through behavior - Kerr choosing his name, Kira refusing to complete an old pattern, Veyris insisting that her body belongs to the life speaking now, and strangers learning to meet again without assuming ownership.

One-Page Synopsis

In 8122, scientist ELI MANA announces evidence that a neural pattern can survive death. His partner KIRA NIX sees the danger before he does: ministers divide access before the discovery is understood. After their daughter SID dies, Eli breaks his promise not to use the receiver to keep her signal alive. Eleven days later the state executes Kira, extracts Eli's memory and turns uncertain science into compulsory Return.

Nearly nineteen centuries later, KERR wakes in a state-grown body with no childhood and 9,997 prior lives attached to his identity. The government insists he is Eli's continuation. During his twenty-seventh review, Kerr draws two women he has never met: Kira and an unassigned host designated V-16. He tears the identity port from his wrist before the state can locate the second woman. His citizenship disappears, and a seventy-two-hour purge begins routing every waiting mind toward High Regent HARP VALE.

Kerr escapes with systems engineer IMANI VOSS and defecting commander SATO. In the Analog Zone he finds Kira alive in a body no one assigned. She remembers loving versions of him but refuses to decide who he is. Together they rescue VEYRIS, the sixteen-year-old V-16, from a sealed reserve. Veyris has memories moving through her but no archived pattern preceding her life. The state and the grieving alike treat her as a container for someone they lost.

At the First Archive, the group uncovers a consent safeguard buried beneath Return. A state tribunal tries to make Kerr legally liable as Eli while denying him Eli's authority. Kira testifies that Eli is dead. Veyris enters the witness field without permission, and the system admits that Kerr's pattern correspondence does not prove identity. Director Roman issues the prepared sentence anyway: forced merge when the purge clock reaches zero.

The contradictory ruling opens records Harp suppressed. Kerr learns that Veyris arrived when the Fracture broke an unassigned route; Kira learns that seven minutes are missing from Sid's death record. Kira remains behind with Sato to draw the state away while Kerr, Veyris and Imani descend. Harp forces Kira through Sid's final night, when Sid made Eli promise not to keep her because he missed her, then reveals that Eli powered the receiver after Kira left.

At the Origin Core, the gate recognizes Kerr by his present self-designation. Sato spends the last of his agency freeing Kira and preserving his daughter Nadi's name rather than his uniform. Roman opens her elevator after seeing his own designation enter the purge queue; Harp kills him. Kerr voluntarily opens the Core as Kerr, not Eli. The withheld record reveals Sid's frightened voice asking Eli to turn off the receiver and go to Kira. Eli starts one more test. Kira publishes the complete record.

Harp seizes Kerr's access and begins the forced merge. Imani refuses a perfect loop of her dead mother and keeps the waiting patterns alive. Veyris's present refusal invalidates Harp as their destination. Kerr opens every dormant route without assigning one, then cuts the filament binding Harp to the waiting minds, knowing the act will erase his own return path. Harp loses his final escape when he stops to watch Mara complete the goodbye he has interrupted for centuries.

Kerr disappears without a recoverable pattern. Across Earth, some people wake, some remain in the grid and some signals go dark; assigned identities fail while the institutions that enforced them remain standing. Kira does not call Kerr back through an inherited name. At the dead Core she taps four notes, receives silence and turns away. Behind her, too faint for any instrument to register, something answers with a fifth.

Feature Treatment

Act One - The Anomaly

A child folds a two-piece red paper star while four notes sound against hospital glass. A fifth answers before any living hand moves. The sound carries into the Global Science Forum in 8122, where Eli Mana presents evidence that thought may continue after death. Kira Nix sees ministers dividing access before the science is understood. Harp Vale watches while holding the medical tag of his dead wife, Mara.

Eleven days later, the first human transfer succeeds and a promised clemency exchange fails. Kira has been executed seven minutes before Eli reaches her cryogenic pod. Her final recording asks him not to chase her if the state puts her in the machine. The state extracts Eli's memory. Over the centuries, Return becomes law, governments become the Chronocracy and natural birth gives way to state-grown bodies. In 9997, the network fractures.

Nine months before the present story, Kerr wakes in iteration 9998 with no childhood and no memory of entering the chamber. Four diagnostic notes sound; his hand answers with a fifth. The waiting patterns beneath Chronos City test every closed route. A message appears on Imani's console - SIGNAL ACKNOWLEDGED - and erases itself.

By day 274, Kerr has built a modest life. He repairs things, burns bread, draws a woman's eye without knowing why and resists every effort to call him Eli. During his twenty-seventh review, supposedly unbreakable glass fractures. Authenticated and unstable records return fragments of Sid, Kira and a consent-locked receiver. Kerr draws Sid's paper star and a girl beneath a black sun before the archive shows him either image.

The review system exposes an unassigned woman known only as V-16 and begins using Kerr's drawings to locate her. Kerr tears the identity port from his wrist. His citizenship, work credential, apartment access and state body license vanish. Imani tells him Harp has started a seventy-two-hour purge that leaves every waiting mind only one destination: Harp.

Harp offers Kerr an end to the cycle if he will open the sealed Origin Core as Eli. Kerr refuses. Security commander Sato, whose loyalty implant is beginning to correct his disobedience, opens a corridor and gives Kerr and Imani forty seconds to run. Their escape route follows a line in Kerr's sketchbook that the state's prediction system cannot see.

Act Two - The Claim

The fugitives enter the Analog Zone, where names and relationships survive outside state authentication. Kerr meets the masked woman from his drawings: Kira, living in a body no one assigned. He wants recognition. She refuses to give him an identity because his gestures feel familiar. Their attraction must become a present decision rather than proof of destiny.

DANE reunites with LENA, his returned wife, but she does not know him. He stops before touching her, introduces himself again and asks permission to sit. Kerr begins to understand what Kira is protecting. Imani admits that she repeatedly restored the renewal appointment her mother chose to cancel.

Kira leads them toward V-16. In a sealed reserve they find VEYRIS, a sixteen-year-old who has already escaped her chamber and begun freeing the people behind her. She chose her own name because it was absent from the forms. When the state closes in, Veyris fights her way into the group's route and experiences unfiltered rain for the first time.

Inside a decommissioned transfer conduit, Kerr abandons the predicted path to rescue Analog refugees. The choice exposes their location. Kira is wounded, Sato takes a round and Veyris refuses to leave him. Their unrecorded ventilation route carries them into the First Archive.

At the archive, mourners ask Veyris to become their dead. She refuses, then asks a grieving father his son's name. The records show Harp knew Kira returned and kept that truth from Eli. They also reveal that Eli restored a consent gate before Harp murdered him: anyone waking with Eli's memories must choose a name for himself.

The group grows closer through choices the state cannot index. Veyris cuts her assigned hair, then finishes the cut herself after Kira mistakes her for Sid. A pea fight becomes the first ordinary family moment Veyris has known. Sato winds the broken watch his daughter Nadi gave him. Kerr and Kira remember lives in which they loved other people and choose to hold hands now without claiming the future.

A preserved record shows Mara refusing rescue at the expense of nine districts. Harp cannot allow the recording to reach the moment she turns away. He continues building a system that violates her choice, while Director Roman discovers that the purge preserves Harp alone.

The Chronocracy captures the group and stages a tribunal to force Kerr into Eli's legal identity. Kira testifies that she remembers Eli - and that Kerr is not him. Veyris enters the witness field without an index and withdraws by choice. R-AI confirms pattern correspondence but refuses to conclude that Kerr is Eli. Roman nevertheless sentences Kerr to forced merge when the purge clock reaches zero.

Act Two - The Withheld Record

The sentence opens records Harp buried. The tribunal's contradictory verdict gives Kerr a claimant key while stripping him of control. In the forbidden memory chamber, Kira admits that part of her waited for Eli to look back. Kerr answers as the person who did.

A preserved Fracture record shows Kira's twelfth body breaking the prediction system in 9997. Through the static, Kerr-9997 sees an empty sixteen-year-old host wake without a mapped continuity pattern. He sketches her face and leaves one instruction before Roman expires him: find me in 9998. Veyris learns the body existed before the Fracture, but she did not. The life answering now is hers.

State forces reach the archive. Kira stays behind to light up Memory Square while Kerr, Veyris and Imani take the descent. Sato remains with Kira as his loyalty implant rewrites him, using the last intervals of his agency to leave doors unlocked.

Harp captures Kira and forces her through Sid's final night. Sid asks whether her parents will still love her if she returns without knowing them. She divides the red paper star between Kira and Eli and makes Eli promise not to turn on the receiver after she dies just because he misses her. Kira taps the four-note question until Sid tells her she can stop.

Harp reveals that Eli's terminal stayed active seven minutes after Kira's record ended. A frightened voice answered, recognized the bent corner of the paper star, asked Eli to turn off the receiver and told him to go after Kira. Eli heard the refusal and began one more test.

Harp offers a bargain: bring him the resonance key, let Kerr open the Core and allow Harp to hold every waiting mind inside himself while the signal is identified. Kira sees the shape of the plan. She refuses to let grief become the one destination left. Above and below, every route converges on the Core.

Act Three - The Purge

Kerr, Veyris and Imani descend toward the Origin Core. The outer gate reads all 9,998 iterations but admits Kerr under his present self-designation. In the detention level, Sato frees Kira by breaking the rhythm his loyalty implant expects. Roman admits that he signed her sentence before the hearing and then saw his own designation enter the purge queue. He holds Kira's elevator channel open until Harp expires him.

Sato gives Kira his mechanical watch and asks her to preserve his daughter Nadi's laugh rather than his uniform. The implant restores perfect loyalty one second before he detonates the level. Kira reaches the Core carrying the watch.

The Core requires voluntary present consent. Kerr's first command fails because he is still answering through fear of Eli. Veyris brings him back to the room. Kerr names himself, keeps his hand on the seal and opens the audit as Kerr.

The withheld seven minutes reveal Sid's voice asking Eli to stop and go to Kira. Eli continues. Kerr does not defend him. Kira strikes Kerr, then refuses to make him apologize for the person whose memory he carries. She releases the complete record publicly and asks R-AI to begin at the flatline.

Harp breaches the Core and uses Kerr's access to begin the forced merge. Expiration clocks across Earth drop to five minutes. Kerr, Kira and Veyris enter the lattice while Imani remains in the physical chamber.

R-AI offers Imani a perfect loop of her dead mother if she closes Kerr's route. Imani lets the record burn and keeps the waiting patterns alive. Veyris refuses the force pulling her into an inherited claimant. Because no archived pattern or assigned destination precedes her, the Core accepts the life speaking now. Harp's destination becomes unsupported.

Kerr opens every dormant route without assigning one, then cuts the filament joining Harp to the waiting minds. Some patterns wake bodies, some remain in the grid and some lose coherence. Harp falls into Mara's final memory. A broken escape route flickers behind him, but he stops when Mara asks him to look at her. The route closes. He watches her go.

Kira closes the resonance key rather than calling Kerr back through an old identity. Kerr disappears without a recoverable pattern. At false dawn, assigned names and expiration dates fail while the Chronocracy's buildings remain. Kira sits between Imani and Veyris beneath the ruined dome. Later she taps four notes against the dead Core. Silence. As she turns away, something answers with a fifth.

Principal Characters

Kerr - The Living Claimant

A man with no childhood and 9,997 prior lives attached to his identity. Kerr's humor is defensive, his anger immediate and his central need simple: to make one decision the past did not make for him. His arc is not discovering who he used to be. It is accepting that the person choosing now is enough, even when that choice costs his next life.

Kira Nix - The Witness Who Refuses Ownership

Scientist, revolutionary, mother and survivor of repeated returns. Kira is not waiting for Kerr to define her story: she is trying to recover and release the seven minutes Harp buried. Her final choice joins that objective to her love for Kerr - she publishes the record, keeps the resonance key closed and accepts the frightened person in front of her without turning love into a command.

Veyris - The Unassigned Life

A sixteen-year-old who arrives during the Fracture in a body with no mapped continuity pattern. Veyris has spent her first year treated as evidence, a key, a daughter, a dead stranger or an empty witness. She chooses her name, cuts her own hair and proves that memories can move through a life without owning it. Her present refusal breaks Harp's forced destination.

High Regent Harp Vale - The Grief That Became Government

Harp could not accept Mara's decision to die rather than sacrifice nine districts for her rescue. He spends centuries building a system in which no one can make that choice again. His remaining sympathy lies in the wound; his danger lies in how quietly he converts love, evidence and emergency authority into permanent control.

Imani Voss - The Engineer of the Open Route

A systems engineer whose mother refused another body. Imani once restored the renewal appointment her mother canceled. In the climax, the system offers her a perfect recording of the person she lost. She lets the loop burn, finally honoring the refusal she once called selfish, and keeps the waiting patterns alive.

Sato - The Man Whose Loyalty Is Being Rewritten

A security commander haunted by the daughter he failed to recognize in time. Sato knows the state can alter his intentions and uses the remaining minutes of his disloyalty to create a choice the prediction system did not expect. He asks Kira to preserve Nadi's laugh and let the uniform die with him.

The World in Plain English

RETURN A measured continuity pattern is routed into a state-grown body. The government treats sufficient correspondence as legal identity; the story leaves the deeper question unresolved.

R-AI The intelligence operating Return. Its public terminals repeat state conclusions, while its buried audit preserves contradictions that the state ordered it to conceal.

THE CHRONOCRACY The government controlling bodies, memory records, identity claims and the timing of death.

THE FRACTURE A brief failure in 9997 that breaks prediction, wakes Veyris through an unassigned route and exposes testimony the system cannot reconcile.

THE RESONANCE KEY Kira's small four-surface ceramic device. It carries the family rhythm through glass and machinery and can test the consent architecture buried beneath Return.

THE ORIGIN CORE The sealed root of Return. Its outer gate recognizes Kerr's present name; its audit layer opens only through voluntary consent that cannot be synthesized from archived memory or coercion.

TRANSIT / DESTINATION / SEVERANCE Transit keeps waiting patterns alive. Destination determines where they go. Veyris's present refusal invalidates Harp as their forced destination. Severance cuts Harp from the lattice and erases Kerr's own return path.

THE FOUR NOTES / FIFTH NOTE A family signal first meaning "Are you still there?" and "I heard you." It links Sid, Kerr, the buried receiver and the final unresolved answer.

Emotional Engine and Themes

The Present Life

Kerr, Kira, Veyris, Lena and Dane face the same practical test: how do you meet the person in front of you when memory insists they should be someone else? The film answers through names, distance, introductions, permission and the willingness to let a person surprise the past.

Consent and Recognition

The central technology is built around a human limit: archived correspondence cannot synthesize present consent. The plot repeatedly turns on that distinction - a hand pulled back, a chair placed at a respectful distance, a name spoken correctly, a route opened without assigning where another mind must go.

Grief and Control

Eli keeps listening. Harp builds a government. Imani restores an appointment her mother canceled. Kira finally stops the pattern. Personal grief expands into architecture, then contracts to one person deciding whether to call another back.

Visual and Sonic Approach

The physical world suggests monumental scale through controlled views: black towers disappear into fog, curved reflections multiply bodies and renewal queues continue beyond sight. Human resistance appears through folded paper, a chipped cup, analog handwriting, burned bread, rain, hand-mended clothing and a mechanical watch that loses four seconds a day.

One architectural language transforms across the Forum, tribunal, Return infrastructure and Core. Color moves from regulated white and cold blue toward candle amber, rust, bruised gold and an imperfect false dawn. Records appear stable; reconstructed memories fray at their edges. The largest spaces are revealed through faces, hands, thresholds and repeated objects.

Sound supplies scale the camera does not need to show. Cooling locks release beyond the visible reserve, unseen queues advance through distant speakers and Sato's watch keeps imperfect time. The climax contracts a planetary system to breathing, a five-minute countdown, a ceramic cover closing and a four-note question left unanswered until the final image.

Audience, Market and Production Frame

Core Audience

Adults drawn to elevated science fiction, emotional mysteries, speculative identity stories and visually ambitious streaming or theatrical features. The accessible entry point is not reincarnation theory; it is the fear that someone else's memory may determine who you are allowed to become.

Comparable Positioning

ARRIVAL Emotional science fiction in which communication and grief drive the speculative architecture.

BLADE RUNNER 2049 A protagonist whose manufactured identity becomes the basis of a personal and political awakening.

ETERNAL SUNSHINE OF THE SPOTLESS MIND Love, memory and the question of whether emotional recognition survives altered identity.

CLOUD ATLAS Relationships and moral choices repeating across bodies, eras and social systems.

The project should be positioned through these audience expectations, not presented as a claim that it duplicates their scale, authorship or commercial performance.

Production Tier

Preliminary development target: a premium, controlled science-fiction feature in the approximately \$45-70 million range before financing, incentives or final line budgeting. The range is illustrative and must be validated by an experienced line producer. The production strategy centers on recurring architecture, contained environments, off-screen scale, projection, sound and selective visual-effects escalation during the final act.

Packaging Priorities

The strongest next attachments are an experienced producer in elevated genre, a director capable of intimate performance inside monumental environments, a recognizable actor for Kerr or Kira, and a production designer/VFX supervisor who can demonstrate a controlled visual strategy before a studio approach.

Initial Buyer Logic

The project is best introduced through producers, managers and genre-focused production companies rather than as an unsupported cold studio submission. The package should make the emotional story understandable before explaining the full mythology.

Creator Statement

I began 9998 with questions about reincarnation: whether a person returning in another body would still be the same person, whether they would remember why they came back, and whether love could survive that uncertainty. For a long time, I understood the premise but not the ending.

I completed the story while processing the death of my father. The film did not give me proof about what happens after death. It gave me a way to write about what grief asks us to do with the people we lose - and the difference between carrying love forward and refusing to let someone go.

That distinction became the center of the screenplay. Kerr does not reject the past because it is meaningless. Kira does not release him because she loves him less. Veyris does not refuse other people's memories because they are unreal. Each character learns that memory can matter without becoming ownership.

9998 is ultimately a story about allowing another person to exist beyond the identity we need from them. If anything survives across lifetimes, the film argues that love is most human when it does not become a command.

Rights and Development Status

AUTHOR Lawrence Ligad Jr.

MATERIAL Original feature screenplay and associated development materials

STATUS Current 85-page studio submission draft; no producer, director, cast or financing attachment represented in this package

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